

WOLGAWURZELN

GENEALOGY OF THE GERMANS FROM RUSSIA



SAMPLE DOCUMENT

ORIGIN REPORT

SCHÄFER

A family name, its colony and the family's path from the Wetterau to
the Volga, to Kazakhstan and back

Büdingen · Norka · Karaganda · Ludwigsburg

1766 to the present

Prepared for the Schäfer family

September 2026

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

SOURCES AND METHOD

An origin report answers three questions: which colony does the name come from, what kind of place was it, and which path did the family take. For the surname Schäfer all three can be answered from published sources, except for one gap, which is named clearly.

The starting point is what the family knows: the grandfather's place and year of birth, the stations after 1941, and the memory that the family came "from the Bergseite".¹ Added to this are the published sources on the colony of Norka: the first settlers list of 1767 with places of origin, the counts of the colony, its local history and the record of persecution after 1941.^{2 3 4 9} Every key statement carries a source number. The findings below grade each statement in three steps: documented, probable, open. Nothing is embellished.

AT A GLANCE

SURNAME	Schäfer, in Russian records Шеефер (Shefer), occasionally Шееффер
COLONY	Norka on the Bergseite, the hilly west bank of the Volga, founded 15 August 1767, Reformed; today Nekrasovo, Saratov oblast
ORIGIN IN GERMANY	The Isenburg territories in the Wetterau, Hesse; for two of the four Schäfer entries of 1767 the villages are confirmed, Wolf near Büdingen and Burgbracht
ADMINISTRATION 1922 TO 1941	Village in the canton of Balzer (until 1927 Golyi Karamysh) of the Volga German Republic
FAMILY ROUTE	1766 emigration, 1767 Norka, 1941 deportation to Karaganda in Kazakhstan, 1942 labor army in Chelyabinsk, 1989 resettlement to Ludwigsburg

FINDINGS

DOCUMENTED	The surname Schäfer has belonged to Norka since its founding in 1767, with four entries, each giving Isenburg as origin. ^{2 3} Founding, denomination, church, population and deportation of the colony. ^{2 4 9}
PROBABLE	The family descends from one of the two entries with a man of this name: Johannes Schäfer (no. 22) or Johann Heinrich Schäfer from Burgbracht (no. 191a). ²
OPEN	The chain of generations between 1767 and Konrad Schäfer*, born about 1845, and with it which of the two entries is the family's root.

Persons marked with an asterisk are fictitious. This document is a sample: the Schäfer* family is invented, while all statements on the colony, sources, places, events and figures are real and documented. A report for your family ends with the generation born in the 1920s; younger relatives are not named with dates.

CHAPTER I

THE NAME SCHÄFER AND ITS ORIGIN

An occupational name found everywhere, and a list from 1767 that ties it to one place. Norka is one of the few colonies whose settlers came largely from the same region.

Schäfer, “shepherd”, is an occupational name and one of the most common German surnames of all. On its own it is never enough to place a family; on the Volga there is even a colony on the Wiesenseite with this name, Schäfer, in Russian Lipovka.⁵ The assignment works through what the family knows: the grandfather Heinrich Schäfer* was born in Norka in 1912, and a copy of his birth record in the family’s possession names the place explicitly.¹

The list of Norka’s founding households of 1767 gives the name four times, each time with Isenburg as place of origin.^{2 3} The Isenburg counties lay in the Wetterau around Büdingen and Birstein; most Norka settlers came from their villages, among them Büdingen itself, Wolf, Burgbracht, Kefenrod, Schlierbach, Lorbach, Pferdsbach, Spielberg and Birstein.²

HOUSEHOLD 1767	PERSONS	ORIGIN PER LIST	CONFIRMED PLACE
no. 22	Johannes Schäfer and Henriette Julianna Schäfer	Isenburg	not yet confirmed
no. 37	Apollonia Schäfer	Isenburg	Wolf near Büdingen
no. 80	Margaretha Schäfer	Isenburg	not yet confirmed
no. 191a	Johann Heinrich Schäfer	Isenburg	Burgbracht

Origin per list from the 1766 ship lists and the 1767 census; confirmed place from church or civil records; as given on [norkarusia.info](#).^{2 3}

WHY THE ASSIGNMENT IS SOUND

Three things fit together. First the place: the family knows that the grandfather was born in Norka, and the copy of his birth record confirms it.¹ Second the time: the name appears in the founding list of 1767, in the censuses and in the local record.² Third the origin: all four Schäfer entries of 1767 name Isenburg, and for two the villages are documented, Wolf and Burgbracht.² What is missing is the chain of generations between 1767 and Konrad Schäfer*, born about 1845. It can be closed with the 1798 census and the church books of Norka; that is the subject of individual research.¹³

FINDINGS

DOCUMENTED Birth of the grandfather in Norka in 1912.¹ Four Schäfer entries in the founding list of 1767, all from Isenburg; Wolf for no. 37, Burgbracht for no. 191a.^{2 3}

PROBABLE Descent from no. 22 (Johannes) or no. 191a (Johann Heinrich); nos. 37 and 80 are households headed by women.²

OPEN The generations between 1767 and 1845, and with them the choice between no. 22 and no. 191a; the home village of no. 22.

CHAPTER II

THE COLONY OF NORKA

From 218 households on the Norka river to the largest village of the Bergseite: 14,000 people before the First World War, emigration to America, famine in 1921, deportation in 1941.

Norka was founded on 15 August 1767 as a crown colony, that is, laid out by the Russian government itself, 65 kilometers southwest of Saratov on the Norka river, which gave the place its name. The main group of settlers arrived that day, further groups followed until 22 September.^{2 4} The count at the end of 1767 gives 218 households with 738 persons, other sources say 753.^{2 4} After its first headman, Johann Conrad Weigandt, the village was also called Weigand; the decree of 26 February 1768, which gave the colonies Russian names, let Norka keep its own.⁴

The congregation was Reformed; in 1767 only 16 families counted as Lutheran and 6 as Catholic.² In 1822 a wooden church was built and later enlarged to 2,500 seats.⁴ The population grew from 1,662 in 1798 to 14,236 in 1912.² From 1875 people from Norka emigrated to America; Lincoln, Nebraska, and Portland, Oregon, became centers of the Norka community.² The famine of 1921 to 1924 halved the population; George Repp, himself from Norka, helped found the Volga Relief Society in Portland and in 1921 led relief work of the American Relief Administration on the spot.²

YEAR	EVENT OR FIGURE
15 August 1767	Founded as a crown colony, 218 households ^{2 4}
1822	Wooden church built, later enlarged to 2,500 seats ⁴
1871	End of the colonists' privileges; seat of Norka volost, Kamyshin district ⁴
1875	First emigrants to the USA, first Ohio, then Nebraska ²
1912	14,236 inhabitants, the peak ²
1921 to 1924	Famine; in 1926 only 7,466 inhabitants ²
1922 to 1941	Village in the canton of Golyi Karamysh, from 1927 canton of Balzer ⁴
September 1941	Deportation; renamed Nekrasovo on 2 July 1942 ⁴

For family research the key sources are the first settlers list of 1767, the censuses of 1775 and 1798 and the church books of the Reformed congregation; the lists are published.^{3 13}

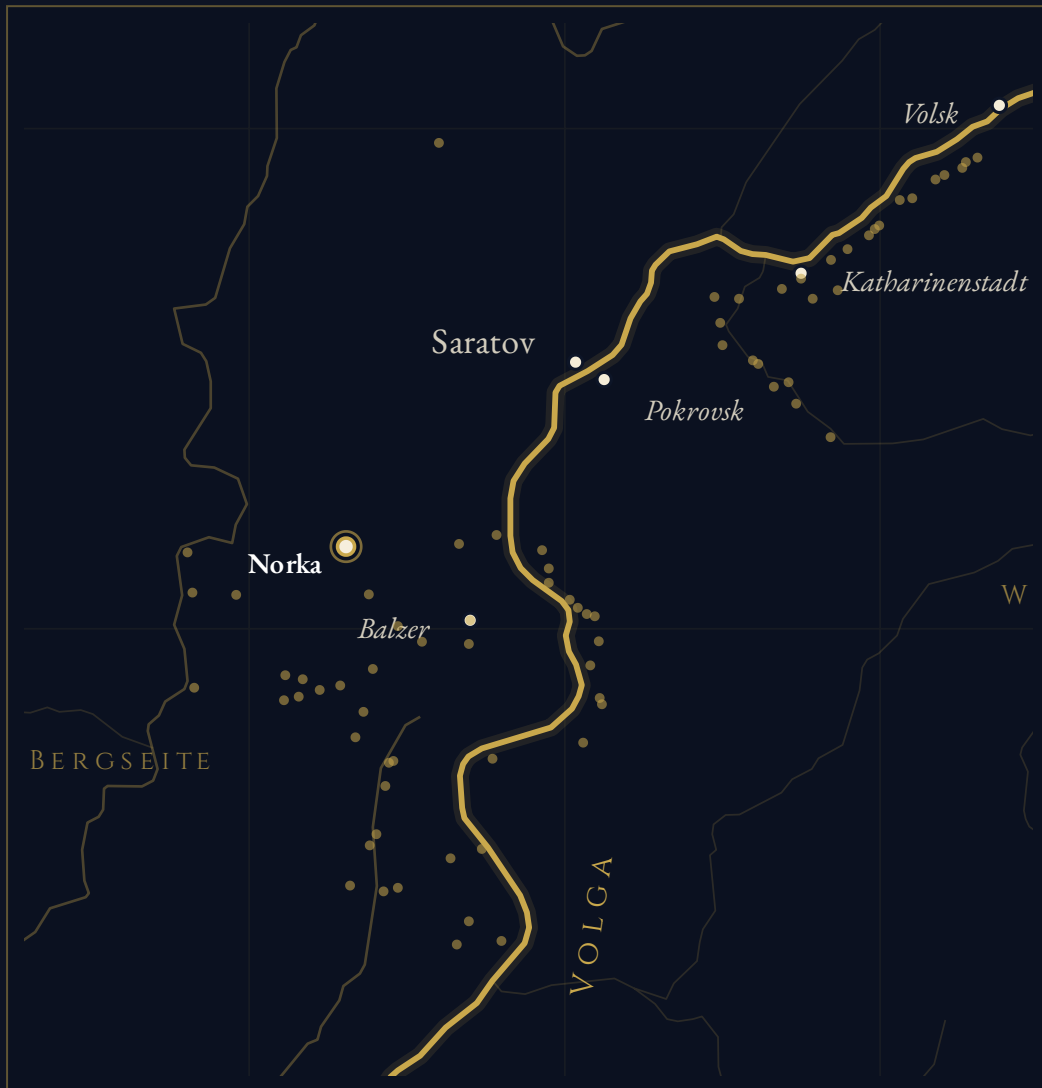
FINDINGS

DOCUMENTED	Founding, name, denomination, church, administration and population of the colony. ^{2 4}
PROBABLE	Like most Norka families, the family lived from farming and in winter from home weaving; there is no record of the occupation.
OPEN	Surviving years of the church books with the family's entries.

MAP

NORKA ON THE BERGSEITE

The Volga between Volsk and Kamyschin. Norka lies on the high western bank, about 65 kilometers southwest of Saratov, in the hill country of the Bergseite.



Norka, highlighted, among the mother colonies of the Bergseite. All colonies with a secured location are shown as dots; towns in English spelling.

CHAPTER III

THE FAMILY'S PATH

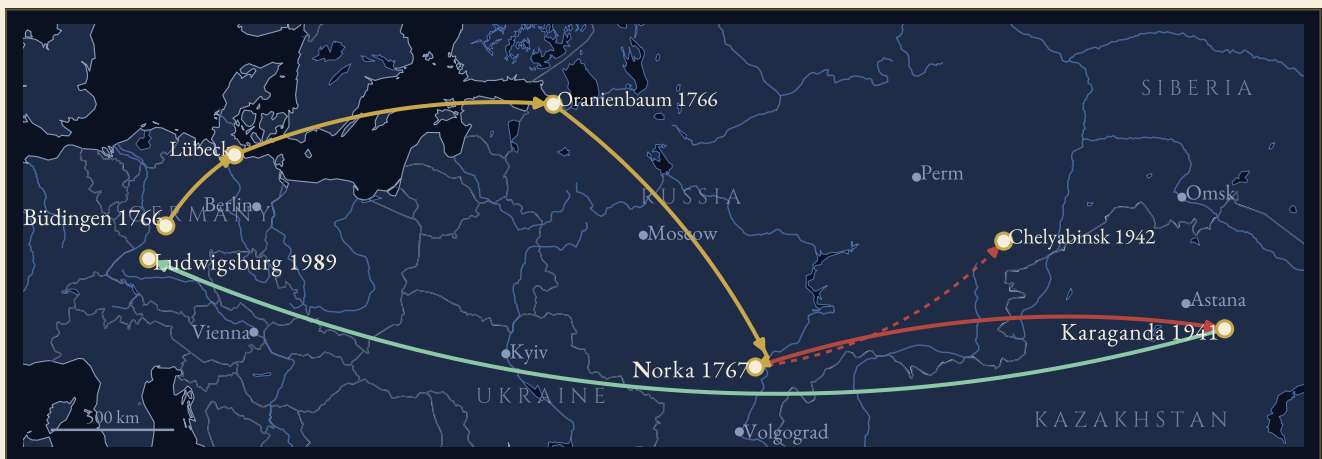
From the Wetterau to the Volga, from the Volga into the steppe, from the steppe back to Germany: 250 years in one arc.

1766 and 1767. Büdingen was one of the most important assembly points of the emigration; in its St. Mary's Church 375 colonist couples were married between 24 February and 8 July 1766 before the treks set out.⁶ From Lübeck the ships sailed to Kronstadt and Oranienbaum, where the emigrants swore the oath of allegiance; most of the later Norka settlers arrived there on 19 and 28 July 1766.^{2,7} Via Saint Petersburg, overland and by river, wintering on the way, they reached the Norka river on 15 August 1767.²

The 19th century. The colony grew from census to census; in 1871 the colonists' privileges ended, in 1874 conscription followed.⁴ Konrad Schäfer*, born about 1845 in Norka, is the first of the line whom the family knows by name; his son Johann Georg Schäfer* was born in 1878 and married Katharina Elisabeth Krieger*, also from Norka.¹ The grandfather Heinrich Schäfer* was born in 1912, the year Norka reached its peak of 14,236 inhabitants.^{1,2}

1941. The decree of 28 August 1941 ordered the deportation of the Volga Germans; the trains ran between 3 and 20 September, and by 25 December the authorities counted 374,717 deportees from the Volga Republic.⁹ The Schäfer* family was sent to the Karaganda region in Kazakhstan. In January 1942 Heinrich Schäfer* was drafted into the labor army and worked until 1946 on the construction site of the metallurgical combine in Chelyabinsk; his father Johann Georg* died in the special settlement in 1944.^{1,10}

From 1955. The komendatura regime ended on 13 December 1955, but return to the Volga remained forbidden; in 1964 a decree withdrew the accusations of 1941.¹¹ In 1989, when 98,134 resettlers came from the Soviet Union, the family moved to Ludwigsburg.¹² Heinrich Schäfer* did not live to see it; he died in Karaganda in 1979.¹



Gold: emigration 1766/67. Red: deportation 1941, dashed: labor army in Chelyabinsk. Green: resettlement to Germany 1989.

TIMELINE

THE SCHÄFER FAMILY IN 16 STATIONS



RESULTS

WHAT THIS REPORT ESTABLISHES

The colony documented

Norka on the Bergseite of the Volga, founded 15 August 1767, Reformed, a volost from 1871, in the Volga Republic a village in the canton of Balzer, today Nekrasovo.

The name in the colony documented

Four Schäfer entries in the founding list of 1767, all giving Isenburg as origin; Wolf near Büdingen and Burgbracht are confirmed.

The origin in Germany documented for the region

The Isenburg territories in the Wetterau, assembly point Büdingen in 1766. Whether the line comes from Burgbracht or another village depends on the choice between no. 22 and no. 191a.

The family's path documented

Via Lübeck and Oranienbaum to Norka, 1941 Karaganda, 1942 labor army in Chelyabinsk, 1989 Ludwigsburg.

OPEN LEADS

Four questions remain, and for each there is a source. They are the natural next step if the origin report is to become individual research.

QUESTION	SOURCE
Does the family descend from no. 22 or from no. 191a?	1798 census of Norka, published ¹³ ; comparison of given names and household numbers
Which Isenburg village did household no. 22 come from?	Büdingen marriage register 1766 ⁶ , church books of the Wetterau via Archion
On which ship did the family reach Oranienbaum?	Kulberg lists 1766 ⁷
Which records of 1941 to 1955 exist for the family?	State archive of the Karaganda region; archive of the Chelyabinsk region for the labor army; rehabilitation files

APPENDIX

SOURCES

1. Information from the Schäfer* family (sample): copy of the grandfather's birth record, 1912, Norka; recollections of the stations from 1941 to 1989.
2. norkarussia.info, Norka, a German Colony in Russia (Steve Schreiber): pages Founders (households of 1767, origin from the 1766 ship lists and the 1767 census, confirmed places from church and civil records), Founding of Norka, Population, Immigration, Famine 1921 to 1924; accessed September 2026.
3. Igor Pleve: Einwanderung in das Wolgagebiet 1764 bis 1767. Göttinger Arbeitskreis, several volumes from 1999 (first settlers lists of the mother colonies).
4. Information system on the settlements of the Germans in Russia, siedlung.rusdeutsch.ru, entry Norka: founding, names, church, population, administration, renaming of 2 July 1942; accessed September 2026.
5. Lexikon der Wolgadeutschen, lexikon.wolgadeutsche.net, article Mariental (volost of Tonkoshurovka with the colony of Schäfer, Russian Lipovka); accessed September 2026.
6. Klaus Peter Decker: Büdingen als Sammelplatz der Auswanderung an die Wolga 1766. Büdingen 2009.
7. Kulberg lists: Igor Pleve, Lists of Colonists to Russia in 1766, Saratov 2010; Andreas Idt and Georg Rauschenbach, Die Kuhlberg Listen, Moscow 2024; overview at volgagermans.org (22,711 colonists in 1766).
8. Karl Stumpp: Die Auswanderung aus Deutschland nach Rußland in den Jahren 1763 bis 1862. Tübingen 1972.
9. Decree of the Presidium of the Supreme Soviet of the USSR of 28 August 1941; Landsmannschaft der Deutschen aus Russland, day of remembrance of the deportation, lmdr.de: 894,626 deportees by 25 December 1941, of them 374,717 from the Volga Republic, according to KGB figures.
10. Encyclopedia of the Germans in Russia, enc.rusdeutsch.eu, article Labor Army: resolutions of the State Defense Committee no. 1123 of 10 January 1942, no. 1281 of 14 February 1942 and no. 2383 of 7 October 1942; Federal Agency for Civic Education (bpb), Informationen zur politischen Bildung, Russlanddeutsche: just over 350,000 people in the labor army, about 150,000 dead.
11. Decrees of 13 December 1955 (end of the komendatura), 29 August 1964 (withdrawal of the accusations) and 3 November 1972 (freedom of residence); as presented by the Federal Agency for Civic Education and the Landsmannschaft der Deutschen aus Russland.
12. Federal Office of Administration (Bundesverwaltungsamt): (Spät)Aussiedler und ihre Angehörigen, time series 1950 to 2022; Federal Agency for Civic Education, facts and figures: 98,134 resettlers from the Soviet Union in 1989, peak of 213,214 in 1994, 2,407,765 in total from 1950 to 2020.
13. Brent Alan Mai (ed.): 1798 Census of the German Colonies along the Volga, Lincoln 1999; The 1775 and 1798 Censuses of the German Colony on the Volga, Norka, AHSGR 1995.

Note. Personal details about the Schäfer* family are based on the family's own information (source 1) and have not in every case been checked against original records. What has been checked carries a source number; what is open is stated in the findings and the open leads. In this sample the family is fictitious.

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RESEARCH FOR YOUR FAMILY

This document is a sample. An origin report or a family history for your own family begins with a free first assessment: you send the surname and, if known, the village or region, and you learn what can be found before any cost arises.

ORIGIN REPORT

39 € one time

- one surname
- assignment to the colony
- history of the colony
- the family's migration route
- PDF in 3 to 5 days

FAMILY HISTORY

69 € one time

- up to four surnames
- origin of every line
- a narrated history
- map and timeline
- PDF in 5 to 8 days

INDIVIDUAL RESEARCH

149 € for 3 hours

- ancestors with names and dates
- requests to archives in Germany and Russia
- report included
- further hours only after your approval

Both reports are also available as a printed photo book for 29 €, shipping within Germany included. All fees are final prices; no VAT is charged under § 19 UStG. Transcriptions of old handwriting are quoted after the scans have been reviewed.

HOW IT WORKS

1 · FIRST ASSESSMENT

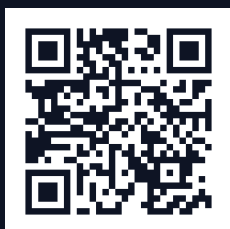
Surname and, if known, village or region, by WhatsApp or email. Reply usually within 24 hours: what can be found, which route makes sense, what it costs. Free of charge.

2 · ORDER

Order with the surname and what you already know. Before the research begins, names and details are reviewed together so that nothing fails because of a spelling variant.

3 · DELIVERY

The report arrives as a PDF with sources, map and timeline. The invoice comes with the report. On request also printed as a photo book.



CONTACT

WhatsApp +49 173 5412807
 edwin@wolgawurzel.de
 wolgawurzel.de

Replies usually within 24 hours, in German, Russian or English.